GALLERY

Art is Alive

Nature Morte art gallery opens in Mumbai with a solo show by Subodh Gupta

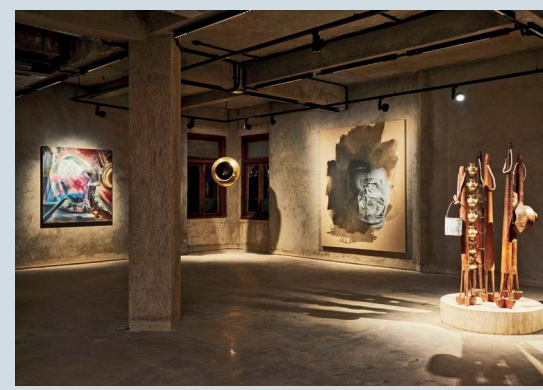
We didn't want a plain white box,'' say gallerists Peter Nagy and Aparajita Jain, who were clear in their vision for Nature Morte's first Mumbai space. The co-directors, with their successful galleries in Delhi's Dhan Mill complex and Vasant Vihar, have finally brought the gallery to Mumbai. ''We wanted it to be dark and moody. We stuck with the raw concrete on the wall but then juxtaposed it with the stainless steel and the wooden doors and played up the windows. So here we are...,'' says Nagy, his hands sweeping in an artistic arc across the expanse. We're at his stylish new art gallery in Dhanraj Mahal, a grand Art Deco palace in Colaba, Mumbai's freshly rejuvenated art precinct. We bump into celebrated Delhi-based artist Subodh Gupta, whose work—titled *A Small Village, Around the Corner, Up in the Mountain* (January 19 to March 9, 2024)—opens this gallery, as it has done for Nagy's other Indian ventures. He's chuffed about showing his latest work in Mumbai. ''This is the seventh solo show that Nature Morte is hosting with Gupta in India, and opening our Mumbai space with him is particularly appropriate,'' says Nagy.

Gupta's show includes sculptures, paintings and wall reliefs, all created in the past few years. Gupta uses everyday household objects as metaphors for the passage of time, our human condition, the bonds of family and community. Nagy feels that the seven paintings in the show are a fresh step for Gupta. A new piece of sculpture, cooking vessels gleaming mysteriously in the dramatic lighting of the gallery, is actually one of three similar ones. ''This one fit the space perfectly and also happens to be my favourite,'' says Nagy. It's also Gupta's favourite in this collection and likely to be much in demand by collectors. There are older wall pieces made from shoeshine boxes that have never been exhibited in India, and two plaster pieces, created during the pandemic, that have not been shown at all.

Gupta isn't the only Delhi artist who has found a new home for his work in Mumbai. ''We're already booked up for the next two years. It will mostly be solo shows by Delhi-based artists and international ones. Thukral and Tagra, and Tanya Goel are some names you can expect in the near future,'' says Nagy. ''In the history of Nature Morte, I've sold more art to people in Mumbai than Delhi because the Mumbai collectors are more adventurous and like more experimental, edgy art, which is what we sell,'' he adds. Since some of their top artists weren't working with anybody in Mumbai, it made sense to have a permanent gallery here to exhibit their work.

Nature Morte Mumbai will also showcase the work of international artists. ''Our next show is by Lorenzo Vittori. He's an Italian photographer who makes wall pieces and sculptures in Jaipur. Then there'll be a German artist in December,'' Nagy lists off the cuff. The advent of the heft of Nature Morte is a welcome addition to Mumbai's vibrant contemporary art scene. ■

–Priya Pathiyan



FIRST SHOW Right, Subodh Gupta's exhibition, *A Small Village, Around the Corner, Up in the Mountain* at Nature Morte Mumbai; below, the artist's work, 'Close to the River Where Wood is Burning'



Photographs Courtesy: NATURE MORTE, NEW DELHI AND MUMBAI